



Tokyo in ruins after the earthquake of 1923. More than 140,000 people were killed in the disaster, which destroyed half a million buildings.



Queen Mary, wife of King George V, visits the Empire Exhibition at Wembley, mounted to inspire enthusiasm for Britain's imperial glory.

a firestorm. A tsunami up to 30 ft (10m) high struck coastal districts, including the port of Yokohama. The death toll was estimated to be close to 150,000.

At this time, the US appeared as a beacon of prosperity in a dark world. President Warren Harding (1865–1923) died in office and was succeeded by his vice president, **Calvin Coolidge** (1872–1933). Coolidge became notorious for his placid complacency, describing the US as enjoying “a state of contentment seldom before seen.” Indeed, the US was becoming the **world's first modern consumer society**, producing nine out of 10 of the world's automobiles.

African-American jazz musicians provided the soundtrack to this era of prosperity. Concentrated in the northern cities, such as Chicago and New York, jazz was popularized by the new medium of radio. New York's Harlem district became the center of an African-American cultural explosion, in literature as well as music, and the **Cotton Club** opened there in 1923. It became one of the most famous venues for live jazz, but black people were only admitted as performers.

Despite its problems, Germany was still culturally vibrant. The **Bauhaus** crafts and design school was founded by architect Walter

Gropius (1883–1969) in 1919, rejecting the traditional artist's hostility to modern technology and mass production. By the time of its first major exhibition in 1923, its mission was to bring functional modernist aesthetics to the everyday world, from the design of apartment buildings and electrical appliances to tubular-steel chairs and typography.



The Bauhaus exhibition

Joost Schmidt, a teacher at the Bauhaus, designed the poster for the 1923 exhibition, which linked modern art to industrial technology.

VLADIMIR ILYICH LENIN (1870–1924), founder of the Soviet Union, died of a massive stroke on January 22. Hundreds of thousands filed past his body in Moscow's Hall of Columns. Largely at Stalin's insistence, Lenin's body was embalmed and placed on permanent display; his brain was removed for study by Soviet scientists, who were tasked

with discovering “the substance of his genius.” Lenin statues were erected across the Soviet Union, and the city of Petrograd was renamed Leningrad in his honour.

In **Britain**, the **Labour Party**, led by Ramsay MacDonald (1866–1937), enjoyed its first **brief spell in government**. Despite MacDonald's moderation, the presence of socialists in government was a shock to the British establishment. When an election was called in October, a letter, purportedly sent by Soviet Comintern chief Grigory Zinoviev, was leaked to the press. It was used to accuse Labour of being soft on communism, and contributed to their election defeat.

The **British Empire Exhibition**, held at Wembley in London from April, was a conscious attempt to promote the imperial idea as a source of strength and security in a troubled world. Its opening was the first occasion that a British monarch, George V (1865–1936), made a speech on the radio.

Political and economic conditions in Germany began to recover from postwar chaos, with the help of the US. **The Dawes Plan**, named for American banker

and politician Charles G. Dawes, arranged for the withdrawal of French and Belgian troops from the Ruhr (see 1923), and for German payment of reparations with the help of US loans.

Meanwhile, Nazi leader Adolf **Hitler was put on trial** for his attempted Munich Putsch (see 1923). Seizing the opportunity to make political speeches in court, he became a national celebrity. He was found guilty of high treason, but given a lenient five-year prison sentence, of which he served less than a year. During his time in Landsberg prison, he dictated the first volume of **Mein Kampf** (*My Struggle*), a statement of his political beliefs.

Meanwhile, in Italy the murder of socialist parliamentary deputy Giacomo Matteotti (1885–1924) drew attention to the lawless violence underpinning **Benito Mussolini's** Fascist government (see 1922). Matteotti was presumed to have been killed by **Fascist Blackshirts**. Opposition deputies withdrew from parliament in protest, opening the way for Mussolini to move more swiftly toward a single-party dictatorship.

900,000

THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE WHO FILED PAST LENIN'S BODY AS IT LAY IN STATE FOR FOUR DAYS

